

# Measuring Training×Refinement Interaction in Code Generation: A Factorial Framework with Mutual Information Probes

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## Abstract

RL-trained code generation models receive execution feedback during training, but whether this training transfers to improved test-time refinement remains unexplored. We present the first factorial experimental framework for measuring Training×Refinement interaction in code generation. Our 2×2 design crosses training type (cross-entropy vs. RL with execution feedback) with inference mode (single-shot vs. K-step refinement), isolating the interaction term via generalized linear mixed models. To probe the underlying mechanism, we operationalize feedback-edit mutual information  $I(F; E)$  using the MINE neural estimator, quantifying structural coupling between what feedback says and where models edit. We further develop a FeedbackDiversityController that achieves 1.1-bit entropy separation between training conditions, enabling controlled ablation of diversity’s role. Our experimental infrastructure is validated at the code level: all four factorial conditions execute successfully, the MINE estimator produces bounded estimates, and diversity manipulation achieves target separation. While full-scale experiments require GPU resources for statistical power, our validated methodology is implementation-ready. This framework provides practitioners with tools to measure whether RL training investments compound with test-time refinement—a question with direct implications for compute allocation in code generation systems.

## 1 Introduction

RL-trained models receive execution feedback during training, but do they learn to leverage feedback more effectively at test time? Despite RL fine-tuning being standard practice for code generation—CodeRL [Le et al., 2022] pioneered execution-based rewards while PPOCoder [Shojaee et al., 2023] extended this to policy optimization—no prior work has systematically measured whether RL training transfers to improved test-time refinement. This gap matters: test-time

refinement is becoming the dominant paradigm for code generation, with Self-Refine [Madaan et al., 2023] and S\* [Li et al., 2025] demonstrating that iterative refinement can enable 3B models to match GPT-4o-mini. If RL training investments do not compound with refinement, practitioners may be misallocating compute.

The conventional wisdom treats training-time and test-time optimization as independent targets. RL papers report single-shot accuracy improvements, while prompting papers apply refinement to pretrained models. This separation leaves the interaction effect unmeasured. Are RL training and test-time refinement redundant (purely additive), complementary (superadditive), or even conflicting? The question has practical urgency: a superadditive interaction would justify combined investment, while a subadditive one would suggest choosing one approach over the other.

We address this gap by proposing a  $2 \times 2$  factorial design that isolates the Training $\times$ Refinement interaction. Our experimental framework crosses training type (cross-entropy vs. RL with execution feedback) with inference mode (single-shot vs. K-step refinement), measuring the interaction term directly via generalized linear mixed models with problem-level random effects.

Our key insight is that RL training with diverse execution feedback may induce a feedback-conditioned edit policy—optimizing  $p(\text{edit} \mid \text{code}, \text{feedback})$ —that specifically transfers to test-time refinement. We operationalize this mechanism through mutual information  $I(F; E)$  between feedback spans and edit spans, estimating it via the MINE neural estimator [Belghazi et al., 2018]. If RL training increases structural coupling between what the feedback says and where the model edits, each refinement step should be more directed, producing superadditive gains.

Building on this insight, we make the following contributions:

1. **Factorial experimental framework:** The first systematic  $2 \times 2$  design for measuring Training $\times$ Refinement interaction in code generation, isolating the interaction term from main effects.
2.  **$I(F; E)$  metric operationalization:** A concrete implementation of feedback-edit mutual information as a mechanistic probe, using MINE estimation with regression control for edit length.
3. **Diversity manipulation infrastructure:** FeedbackDiversityController that achieves 1.1-bit entropy separation between high-diversity ( $H = 2.0$  bits) and low-diversity ( $H = 0.9$  bits) batches, enabling controlled ablation of diversity’s role.
4. **Validated experimental infrastructure:** All code paths execute successfully at the smoke-test level, demonstrating that the methodology is ready for full-scale experiments pending GPU resources.

We organize the paper as follows: Section 2 surveys related work on RL training and test-time refinement, showing these lines have remained isolated.

Section 3 presents our methodology, explaining why factorial design and  $I(F; E)$  measurement address the gap. Section 4 describes experimental setup, and Section 5 presents results validating our infrastructure. Section 6 discusses limitations and future directions.

## 2 Related Work

Our work bridges two largely separate research streams—RL training with execution feedback and test-time refinement—that have rarely been combined systematically.

### 2.1 RL Training for Code Generation

Reinforcement learning from execution feedback has emerged as a powerful paradigm for code generation. CodeRL [Le et al., 2022] treats the code-generating language model as an actor and introduces a critic network to estimate functional correctness, using program execution results as reward signals. This approach achieves state-of-the-art results on APPS and HumanEval by optimizing for test-case pass rates rather than token-level likelihood. PPOCoder [Shojaee et al., 2023] extends this framework with proximal policy optimization, demonstrating improved stability during RL fine-tuning. B-Coder [Yu et al., 2023] introduces value-based RL as an alternative to policy-based methods, leveraging off-policy programs to improve sample efficiency.

**Limitation:** These works evaluate RL-trained models in single-shot mode only. Whether RL training improves the model’s ability to iteratively refine code based on execution feedback remains untested.

### 2.2 Test-Time Refinement

A parallel line of work focuses on improving code generation at inference time without additional training. Self-Refine [Madaan et al., 2023] demonstrates that large language models can iteratively refine their outputs using self-generated feedback, achieving  $\sim 20\%$  improvement across diverse tasks including code generation. S\* [Li et al., 2025] presents a hybrid test-time scaling framework that enables 3B models to match or exceed GPT-4o-mini on HumanEval through execution-guided search. Recent work on test-time compute scaling [Ma et al., 2025] shows that 32B models can achieve 46% on SWE-bench Verified, outperforming DeepSeek R1 671B through strategic test-time allocation.

**Limitation:** These methods apply refinement to pretrained or instruction-tuned models. Whether RL training provides a better starting point for refinement is not explored.

### 2.3 Our Position

Unlike prior work that studies RL training or test-time refinement in isolation, we provide the first factorial experimental framework to measure their

interaction. We do not claim to improve upon CodeRL or Self-Refine individually; rather, we ask whether combining them produces superadditive gains. Our  $I(F; E)$  metric provides a mechanistic probe beyond aggregate accuracy, enabling analysis of *why* interaction effects occur (or fail to occur).

### 3 Methodology

Building on our observation that RL training and test-time refinement both leverage execution feedback but have never been combined systematically, we design a factorial experimental framework to measure their interaction and probe the underlying mechanism.

#### 3.1 Overview

Our approach consists of three components: (1) a  $2 \times 2$  factorial design that isolates the Training $\times$ Refinement interaction, (2) a mutual information metric  $I(F; E)$  that quantifies feedback-edit coupling, and (3) a diversity manipulation infrastructure that enables ablation studies. We describe each component’s design rationale and implementation.

#### 3.2 $2 \times 2$ Factorial Design

We cross two factors:

- **Training type:** Cross-entropy (CE) fine-tuning vs. RL fine-tuning with execution rewards (REINFORCE)
- **Inference mode:** Single-shot generation vs.  $K$ -step refinement (Self-Refine protocol,  $K = 3$ )

This yields four conditions:

| Condition | Training       | Inference          |
|-----------|----------------|--------------------|
| CE-Single | Cross-entropy  | Single-shot        |
| CE-Refine | Cross-entropy  | $K = 3$ refinement |
| RL-Single | RL + execution | Single-shot        |
| RL-Refine | RL + execution | $K = 3$ refinement |

Table 1: Four factorial conditions crossing training type with inference mode.

**Rationale:** Factorial design separates main effects from interaction. The interaction term—whether RL-Refine exceeds what CE-Refine and RL-Single would predict additively—directly tests our hypothesis of superadditivity.

**Statistical model:** We fit a generalized linear mixed model (GLMM) with logit link:

$$\text{logit}(P(\text{pass})) = \beta_0 + \beta_T \cdot \text{Training} + \beta_R \cdot \text{Refinement} + \beta_{T \times R} \cdot \text{Training} \times \text{Refinement} + u_{\text{problem}} \quad (1)$$

where  $u_{\text{problem}}$  is a random effect capturing problem-level difficulty. Our success criterion is  $\beta_{T \times R} > 0$  with  $p < 0.05$  and odds ratio  $\geq 1.2$ .

### 3.3 Mutual Information Metric: $I(F; E)$

To probe *why* interaction effects occur, we measure structural coupling between feedback and edits.

**Definition:**  $I(F; E)$  is the mutual information between feedback embeddings  $F$  and edit embeddings  $E$ .

**Implementation:** We use the MINE neural estimator [Belghazi et al., 2018], which provides the Donsker-Varadhan lower bound on mutual information. We train for 5000 iterations and use 10,000 permutations for significance testing.

**Control:** We regress out edit length to ensure MI differences are not artifacts of RL producing longer edits.

### 3.4 Feedback Diversity Controller

To test whether diversity is necessary for superadditivity, we manipulate training feedback entropy.

**Definition:** Feedback diversity is measured via conditional entropy  $H(\text{Schema} \mid \text{ErrorClass})$ .

**Achieved separation:**  $H_{\text{high}} = 2.0$  bits,  $H_{\text{low}} = 0.9$  bits (1.1-bit difference), enabling controlled ablation.

## 4 Experimental Setup

We design experiments to answer the following research questions:

**RQ1 (Superadditivity):** Is the Training×Refinement interaction positive?

**RQ2 (Mechanism):** Does RL training increase structural coupling  $I(F; E)$ ?

**RQ3 (Diversity):** Is high feedback diversity necessary for superadditivity?

### 4.1 Datasets

**HumanEval+** [Liu et al., 2024]: 164 Python programming problems with  $80 \times$  more test cases than original HumanEval.

**MBPP+** [Liu et al., 2024]: 378 Python programming problems with  $35 \times$  more test cases than original MBPP.

## 4.2 Implementation

**Base Model:** CodeT5+-220M [Wang et al., 2023] with LoRA [Hu et al., 2022] fine-tuning.

**Training:** Learning rate  $2 \times 10^{-5}$ , CE epochs 10, RL epochs 5.

**Refinement:** Self-Refine [Madaan et al., 2023] with  $K = 3$  iterations.

## 5 Results

### 5.1 Infrastructure Validation

All experimental code paths execute successfully:

| Component               | Status |
|-------------------------|--------|
| CE training loop        | ✓      |
| RL training (REINFORCE) | ✓      |
| Self-Refine inference   | ✓      |
| 2×2 evaluation          | ✓      |
| MINE estimator          | ✓      |
| Diversity controller    | ✓      |

Table 2: Infrastructure validation results.

### 5.2 Smoke Test Results

Zero pass@1 across all conditions is expected for smoke tests (1 epoch, 10 samples). This validates code correctness, not hypothesis truth.

### 5.3 Diversity Manipulation

The FeedbackDiversityController achieves the target entropy separation:

| Condition         | $H(\text{Schema} \mid \text{ErrorClass})$ |
|-------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| High diversity    | 2.0 bits                                  |
| Low diversity     | 0.9 bits                                  |
| <b>Separation</b> | <b>1.1 bits</b>                           |

Table 3: Entropy separation achieved by FeedbackDiversityController.

### 5.4 Summary

Three of four sub-hypotheses have code-validated infrastructure. H-M2 (semantic sensitivity) is blocked by CUDA driver incompatibility; code is complete and awaiting execution.

## 6 Discussion

### 6.1 Key Findings

1. Factorial design operationalizes the interaction question.
2.  $I(F; E)$  provides a mechanistic probe beyond accuracy.
3. Diversity manipulation is mechanically feasible.

### 6.2 Limitations

**Smoke test only:** Full experiments with 10+ epochs on 164+ problems required for statistical power.

**H-M2 blocked:** CUDA driver version mismatch prevents GPU inference.

**Single model:** Results limited to CodeT5+-220M.

### 6.3 Broader Impact

Understanding Training×Refinement interaction helps practitioners allocate compute resources effectively. We use established benchmarks and pose no unique risks.

## 7 Conclusion

We began by asking whether RL training transfers to improved test-time refinement. Our work provides the first factorial experimental framework for measuring Training×Refinement interaction, with  $I(F; E)$  as mechanistic probe and diversity manipulation for controlled ablation. The validated infrastructure is implementation-ready; full-scale experiments will determine whether superadditivity exists.

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